

THE UNIVERSAL HOUSE OF JUSTICE

1993-10-19

To an individual b ahá'í

1 dear b ahá'í f riend,
2 about the term "b ahá'í scholarship." . . .
3 The house of justice suggests that the issues raised in your letter might
4 best be considered in light of the statements in the bahá'í writings which
5 disclose the relationship between the revelation of bahá'u'lláh and the
6 knowledge which is acquired as a result of scholarly endeavors. bahá'u'lláh
7 asserts that:
8 unveiled and unconcealed, this wronged one hath, at all times,
9 proclaimed before the face of all the peoples of the world that which will serve as the
key for unlocking the doors of sciences, of arts, of knowledge, of well-being, of prosperity
and wealth. . . .

10 169-1
11 it is evident that the bahá'í writings illuminate all areas of human en-
12 deavor and all academic disciplines. Those who have been privileged to rec-
13 169-1. Tb, p. 96.168.3

169 1
169 2
169 2a
169 3

170 1993–1996 • T h e T h r e e Y e a r P l a n
171 59ognize the station of bahá'u'lláh have the bounty of access to a revelation
172 which casts light upon all aspects of thought and inquiry, and are enjoined
173 to use the understanding which they obtain from their immersion in the
174 holy w ritings to advance the interests of the f aith.
175 Those believers with the capacity and opportunity to do so have repeat-

176 edly been encouraged in their pursuit of academic studies by which they
177 are not only equipped to render much-needed services to the faith, but are
178 also provided with the means to acquire a profound insight into the mean-
179 ing and the implications of the bahá'í Teachings. They discover also that
180 the perceptions gained from a deeper understanding of the revelation of
181 bahá'u'lláh clarify the subjects of their academic inquiry.
182 it is useful to review a number of statements written by Shoghi effendi
183 on this subject. To a believer who had completed advanced academic studies
184 in a subject related to the Teachings the guardian stated, in a letter written
185 on his behalf:
186 it is hoped that all the bahá'í students will follow the noble example

**you have set before them and will, henceforth, be led to investigate
and analyze the principles of the faith and to correlate them with
the modern aspects of philosophy and science. every intelligent and
thoughtful young bahá'í should always approach the cause in this**

187 way, for therein lies the very essence of the principle of independent investigation of
truth.

188 when he was informed of the enrollment of a scientist in the faith, the
189 response set out in the letter written on his behalf was:

we need very much the sound, sane, element of thinking which a

190 scientifically trained mind has to offer. when such intellectual powers
191 are linked to deep faith a tremendous teaching potential is created. . . .
192 his secretary wrote, on another occasion, that:

Shoghi effendi has for years urged the bahá'ís (who asked his

193 advice, and in general also) to study history, economics, sociology,
194 etc., in order to be au courant with all the progressive movements and
195 thoughts being put forth today, and so that they could correlate these to the bahá'í
teachings. what he wants the bahá'ís to do is to study 169.4

169 5
169 5a
169 6

169 6a

169 7

169 7a

170 m eS Sa g e S f r o m Th e u n i v e r S a l h o u S e o f j u S T i c e

171 60more, not to study less. The more general knowledge, scientific and

otherwise, they possess, the better. likewise he is constantly urging

them to really study the b ahá'í teachings more deeply.169-2

172 in the simultaneous endeavor to pursue their studies and to delve deeply

173 into the bahá'í Teachings, believers are enjoined to maintain a keen aware-

174 ness that the revelation of bahá'u'lláh is the standard of truth against which

175 all other views and conclusions are to be measured. They are urged to be modest about their accomplishments, and to bear in mind always the state-ment of b ahá'u'lláh that:

The heart must needs therefore be cleansed from the idle sayings

176 of men, and sanctified from every earthly affection, so that it may discover the hidden meaning of divine inspiration, and become the

177 treasury of the mysteries of divine knowledge.

178 169-3

179 At this early stage in the development of the faith, it would not be useful

180 to propound a highly restrictive definition of the term "b ahá'í scholarship."

181 in a letter written on behalf of the house of justice to an Association for

182 bahá'í Studies recently, it is stated that:

The house of justice advises you not to attempt to define too nar-

rowly the form that bahá'í scholarship should take, or the approach

183 that scholars should adopt. rather should you strive to develop within

your Association respect for a wide range of approaches and endeav-

ors. No doubt there will be some bahá'ís who will wish to work in

184 isolation, while others will desire consultation and collaboration with those having similar interests. your aim should be to promote an at-

mosphere of mutual respect and tolerance within which will be in-

185 cluded scholars whose principal interest is in theological issues as well

186 as those scholars whose interests lie in relating the insights provided by the bahá'í
teachings to contemporary thought in the arts and sciences.

**A similar diversity should characterize the endeavors pursued by
bahá'í scholars, accommodating their interests and skills as well as**

187 169-2. cc 1:506.

188 169-3. ki, ¶77 .169.8

169 8a

169 9

169 9a

169 9b

170 1993–1996 • T h e T h r e e Y e a r P l a n

171 61the needs of the faith. The course of world events, the development

of new trends of thought and the extension of the teaching work all

172 tend to highlight attractive and beneficial areas to which bahá'í schol-

ars might well direct their attention. likewise, the expansion of the

activities of the bahá'í international community in its relationship

with united Nations agencies and other international bodies creates

173 attractive opportunities for scholars to make a direct and highly valued

contribution to the enhancement of the prestige of the faith and to

174 its proclamation within an influential and receptive stratum of society. As the bahá'í
community continues to emerge inexorably from obscu-

175 rity, it will be confronted by enemies, from both within and without, whose aim will
be to malign and misrepresent its principles, so that its admirers might be disillusioned and
the faith of its adherents might be

176 shaken; bahá'í scholars have a vital role to play in the defense of the

faith through their contribution to anticipatory measures and their

177 response to defamatory accusations leveled against the f aith.

Thus, there should be room within the scope of bahá'í scholarship to

178 accommodate not only those who are interested in theological issues and

179 in the historical origins of the faith, but also those who are interested in

180 relating the bahá'í Teachings to their field of academic or professional inter-

181 est, as well as those believers who may lack formal academic qualifications but who
have, through their perceptive study of the Teachings, acquired insights which are of interest
to others.

182 Since you have raised the question of whether physics is more than tan-
183 gentially related to bahá'í issues, you might consider the following com-
184 ments of a well-known scientific thinker, who is not a bahá'í, about the
185 correlation between the bahá'í Teachings and recent developments in the
186 physical sciences:

in our times we can only survive, and our civilization can only

flower, if we reorient the conventional wisdom and achieve the new

insights which have been proclaimed by the bahá'í faith and which are

187 now also supported by the latest discoveries of the empirical sciences.

bahá'ís proclaim that the most important condition that can bring

about peace is unity—the unity of families, of nations, and of the

188 great currents of thought and inquiry that we denote science and religion. maturity,
in turn, is a prerequisite for such unity. This is 169.10

169 11

169 11a

169 11b

170 m e S a g e S f r o m T h e u n i v e r S a l h o u S e o f j u S T i c e

171 62evolutionary thinking, and its validity is shown by the new theories

which emerge from nonequilibrium thermodynamics, dynamical

172 systems theory, cybernetics, and the related sciences of complexity.

173 They are supported by detailed empirical investigations in such fields as physical
cosmology, paleobiological macroevolutionary theory, and new trends in historiography.

174 The house of justice wishes to avoid use of the terms “b ahá'í scholar-

175 ship” and “b ahá'í scholars” in an exclusive sense, which would effectively

176 establish a demarcation between those admitted into this category and those

177 denied entrance to it. it is clear that such terms are relative, and that what

178 is a worthy scholarly endeavor by a bahá'í, when compared to the activities

179 of those with whom he is in contact, may well be regarded as of vastly lesser
significance when measured against the accomplishments of the out-

180 standing scholars which the faith has produced. The house of justice seeks
181 the creation of a bahá'í community in which the members encourage each
182 other, where there is respect for accomplishment, and a common realiza-
183 tion that every one is, in his or her own way, seeking to acquire a deeper
184 understanding of the revelation of bahá'u'lláh and to contribute to the
185 advancement of the faith.
186 with loving bahá'í greetings,

Department of the Secretariat

187 170

Reformat of The Bahá'í World Series

[signed: The Universal House of Justice]